THE CHURCH, POLITICS AND THE COMMON GOOD

Safeguarding Ecclesial Unity, Mission and Credibility in Nigeria

An Editorial Synthesis of the 38th Annual Convention of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria (CLSN)

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Editorial Work by

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Introduction

The relationship between the Church and politics remains a pressing moral, pastoral and canonical concern in contemporary Nigeria. Faced with insecurity, corruption, economic hardship, political instability, and threats to human dignity, the Church cannot remain indifferent to society's challenges. Nevertheless, its involvement in public affairs must remain faithful to the Gospel, Catholic social teaching and canonical discipline.

This concern informed the 38th Annual Convention of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria (CLSN), held in Enugu from 27 to 30 October 2026, under the theme "Canon Law and Clerical Political Engagement in Nigeria: Ensuring Ecclesial Unity, Mission, and Credibility."

In his Presidential Address, Rev. Fr. Edwin Nosakhare Omorogbe, JCD, PhD, emphasized that canon law is fundamentally a pastoral instrument for promoting justice, safeguarding rights, strengthening ecclesial communion and advancing the salvation of souls.

The convention brought together perspectives from Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, Bishop Emeritus of Enugu; Peter Ndubuisi Mbah, Governor, Enugu State; Ikechukwu Onuoma, SAN; and the scholarly contributions of Bulus Makama, Raphael Ejimonye, Charles Ndubisi and Emmanuel Kazah.

Together, these interventions addressed a fundamental question: how can the Church contribute meaningfully to responsible governance and national development without compromising its spiritual independence, ecclesial unity and public credibility?

1. The Church's Moral Responsibility and the Common Good

Although the Church's mission is primarily spiritual, it necessarily extends to the moral dimensions of political and social life. Justice, peace, religious freedom, responsible governance and human dignity are legitimate concerns of Christian faith.

The Second Vatican Council, particularly Gaudium et Spes (nn. 74-76), affirms the proper distinction between the Church and political society while recognizing their respective

contributions to the common good. Similarly, canon 747 Section 2 acknowledges the Church's right to proclaim moral principles concerning the social order.

The keynote contribution of Peter Ndubuisi Mbah brought the perspective of public governance into the discussion, emphasizing the importance of leadership directed towards society's welfare and development. Ikechukwu Onuoma, SAN, in his inaugural paper, further examined the relationship between law, public responsibility, justice and the common good.

In his homily on the Feast of Saints Simon and Jude, Bishop Anthony Gbuji offered a complementary biblical understanding of governance. Drawing from Ephesians 2:19-22 and Luke 6:12-19, he presented Christ as the cornerstone of justice and responsible leadership. Jesus' prayerful selection of the apostles demonstrates the importance of discernment, while the diversity of the Twelve illustrates that genuine leadership must transcend ethnic, political and social divisions.

Bishop Gbuji further emphasized that authority must be understood as service. Just as Christ exercised his authority to heal, ecclesiastical and civil leadership should protect the vulnerable, restore justice and promote human flourishing.

The Church must therefore remain a prophetic voice against corruption, oppression and injustice without becoming an instrument of partisan political interests. Political neutrality must never be confused with moral indifference.

2. Canonical Discipline and Clerical Political Engagement

The canonical framework governing clerical involvement in politics is principally established by canons 285 Section 3 and 287 Section 2 of the 1983 Code of Canon Law.

Canon 285 Section 3 prohibits clerics from assuming public offices that involve participating in the exercise of civil power. Canon 287 Section 2 restricts their active involvement in political parties and the governing of labour unions unless, in the judgment of competent ecclesiastical authority, such participation is required for the defence of the Church's rights or the promotion of the common good.

Bulus Makama and Raphael Ejimonye examined the canonical implications of clerical political engagement, including the distinction between legitimate civic advocacy, partisan political activity, and the exercise of civil authority.

Bishop Gbuji reinforced this distinction by explaining that canonical restrictions are not meant to silence priests or diminish the Church's prophetic responsibility. Rather, they protect the Church's universality, the impartiality of pastoral ministry, the integrity of sacred orders, and ecclesial unity.

Consequently, a priest who condemns corruption, advocates credible elections or defends fundamental human rights does not necessarily engage in prohibited partisan politics. However,

assuming political office or becoming actively identified with political parties raises distinct canonical and pastoral concerns.

The exception contemplated by canon 287 Section 2 requires the judgment of competent ecclesiastical authority and does not automatically remove the separate prohibition established by canon 285 Section 3. Canon 288 also provides relevant qualifications concerning permanent deacons, subject to particular law.

The governing principle is that priestly ministry must remain sufficiently independent to serve all the faithful, irrespective of political affiliation.

3. Ecclesial Unity, Political Independence and Public Credibility

Nigeria's political environment is frequently influenced by ethnic, regional, religious and economic interests. Under such circumstances, publicly identifying a priest with a political party can divide the faithful and weaken confidence in his pastoral impartiality.

Charles Ndubisi and Emmanuel Kazah's contributions addressed dimensions of the Church's public witness, ecclesial unity, responsible civic engagement, and institutional credibility.

Bishop Gbuji deepened this discussion by drawing on Christ's choice of apostles from different social and political backgrounds. Their unity in Christ demonstrates that the Church must transcend divisions rather than reproduce them.

He identified increasing clerical politicization, public scandal, ideological pressures, inadequate canonical formation and weak disciplinary enforcement as challenges confronting ecclesiastical leadership.

The Church's credibility depends not only on the moral principles it proclaims but also on its fidelity to those principles in its internal governance. Transparency, accountability, respect for rights, fair hearing and responsible administration are therefore indispensable.

A Church that advocates justice in society must also demonstrate justice within its own institutions.

4. The Political Vocation of the Laity

The distinction between clerical and lay responsibilities is essential to the Church's engagement with political society.

While priests are principally entrusted with preaching, sacramental ministry, and the formation of consciences, lay Catholics have a particular vocation to participate directly in political institutions and transform temporal society.

The Second Vatican Council, especially Apostolicam Actuositatem (n. 7) and Gaudium et Spes (n. 75), emphasizes the responsibility of the laity to contribute to political, economic and social development.

The Church must therefore strengthen the ethical and political formation of lay Catholics, encouraging responsible citizenship, democratic participation, accountability and leadership inspired by Catholic social teaching.

The responsibilities of clergy and laity are complementary rather than competitive. Both contribute to the common good through distinct forms of Christian witness.

5. Canon Law, Good Governance and Pastoral Service

In his Presidential Address, Rev. Fr. Edwin Nosakhare Omorogbe emphasized that canon law must remain an instrument of justice, communion and pastoral charity. Canonists are called to assist ecclesiastical authorities through sound legal interpretation, protection of rights, respect for
due process and responsible institutional administration.

Bishop Gbuji reinforced this understanding by insisting that canonical authority must heal rather than wound. Whether in matrimonial tribunals, ecclesiastical administration or disciplinary procedures, the application of law should protect the innocent, correct injustice, restore communion and promote the spiritual welfare of the faithful.

He also identified two priorities that require greater attention from Nigerian canonists.

The first is evangelizing catechesis. Bishop Gbuji observed that violations of ecclesiastical discipline often stem from inadequate formation and a limited understanding of the faith. Canonists should therefore support bishops and dioceses in promoting sustained catechetical education, sound ecclesial identity and responsible Christian living.

The second is inculturation. The Gospel must take root within the cultural traditions of Nigerian communities without compromising Christian doctrine or ecclesiastical discipline. Canon lawyers have a responsibility to help the Church discern which cultural practices may be accepted, purified, corrected, or rejected. Bishop Gbuji acknowledged the scholarly contribution of Rev. Fr. Michael Chime, JCD, to this important field.

These priorities demonstrate that the relevance of canon law extends beyond juridical administration to evangelization, cultural discernment and the formation of Christian conscience.

6. Bishop Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji: Founding Vision and Enduring Legacy

Celebrating Bishop Gbuji’s 95th birthday on 29 October 2026 gave the convention profound historical and spiritual significance.

In his address on 28 October, Bishop Gbuji recalled the origins of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria, tracing its early development to the canonical initiatives undertaken in 1975 to strengthen the institutional structures of the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria.

He explained how canonists from different ecclesiastical provinces collaborated to develop the juridical structures the Nigerian Church required. Their efforts contributed to the establishment and growth of the CLSN, officially approved by the CBCN in 1982, and subsequently organized as a professional association of canonists.

Among the Society's significant achievements were contributions to Nigeria's complementary norms, canonical formularies, the development of canonical studies at the Catholic Institute of West Africa, and the establishment of regional ecclesiastical tribunals.

Bishop Gbuji's reflections highlighted the importance of institutional memory, scholarly collaboration and continuity in ecclesiastical governance.

His episcopal ministry likewise demonstrated a commitment to priestly formation, evangelization, education and institutional development. The convention's celebration of his life affirmed that authentic leadership is measured not simply by immediate achievements but by the institutions, values and opportunities established for future generations.

The presentation of the Festschrift, Servant of the Law, Shepherd of the Flock: Honouring a Living Legacy - Ninety-Five Years of Faith, Canonical Wisdom, and Pastoral Leadership, edited by Rev. Fr. Edwin Nosakhare Omorogbe, JCD, PhD, provided a lasting scholarly tribute to his contribution to the Church in Nigeria.

The late Archbishop Augustine Obiora Akubeze's generosity made the publication possible, with subsequent support from Bishop Donatus Ogun, OSA.

Bishop Gbuji's legacy thus reinforces a central lesson of the convention: responsible leadership requires vision, fidelity to principle, service to others and commitment to enduring institutions.

7. Concrete Recommendations and the Way Forward

The convention's deliberations provide a foundation for practical action. The following recommendations synthesise the principal proposals and pastoral implications of the presentations, rather than a verified record of formally adopted convention resolutions.

1. Strengthening canonical guidelines: The Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria, in collaboration with the CLSN, should consider providing clearer pastoral and canonical guidance on clerical political engagement, particularly concerning canons 285 Section 3 and 287 Section 2.

2. Promoting continuing canonical formation: Seminaries, dioceses and ecclesiastical institutions should strengthen education in canon law, Catholic social teaching, political responsibility and ethical public communication.

3. Preserving priestly impartiality: Clergy should avoid partisan identification while courageously defending justice, peace, religious freedom and human dignity.

4. Empowering the laity: Catholic institutions and lay associations should promote political education, responsible citizenship and ethical leadership, enabling lay Catholics to participate effectively in public affairs.

5. Ensuring ecclesiastical accountability: Church institutions should demonstrate transparency, responsible stewardship, due process, protection of rights and fidelity to canonical discipline.

6. Strengthening evangelizing catechesis: Following Bishop Gbuji's recommendation, dioceses and Catholic institutions should prioritize continuing formation in the faith, helping Catholics understand and fulfil their ecclesial responsibilities.

7. Promoting responsible inculturation: Canonists and pastoral leaders should collaborate in evaluating cultural practices in the light of the Gospel, Catholic doctrine and ecclesiastical law.

8. Developing canonical institutions: The CLSN should continue supporting ecclesiastical tribunals, canonical scholarship, professional formation and advisory services to dioceses and religious institutes.

9. Encouraging dialogue and national reconciliation: The Church should foster cooperation, peaceful coexistence, responsible governance and the protection of human dignity without compromising its spiritual independence.

10. Preserving institutional continuity: Inspired by Bishop Gbuji's founding vision, the Society should strengthen its structures, preserve its historical records, promote scholarship and prepare future generations of canonists for service to the Church.

The implementation of these recommendations requires collaboration among the CBCN, diocesan authorities, the CLSN, seminaries, Catholic educational institutions and lay organizations.

Conclusion

The 38th Annual Convention of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria reaffirmed that the Church has both a moral responsibility to engage the challenges confronting Nigerian society and a canonical obligation to preserve its spiritual independence, ecclesial unity and credibility.

The convention speakers' contributions demonstrated that political engagement must be guided by the common good, respect for human dignity, canonical discipline, and the distinctive responsibilities of clergy and laity.

Bishop Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji's homily and keynote address enriched these deliberations by presenting Christ as the cornerstone of good governance, authority as service, and canon law as an instrument of justice, healing and ecclesial communion. His emphasis on evangelizing

catechesis and inculturation further demonstrated that the Church's credibility depends not only on sound juridical structures but also on the formation of conscience and the effective transmission of faith.

The Church cannot remain silent in the face of injustice, nor can it surrender its spiritual mission to partisan political interests. Its responsibility is to form consciences, defend human dignity, promote reconciliation and inspire responsible participation in society.

The celebration of Bishop Gbuji's 95th birthday provided a living testimony to the enduring value of faithful leadership, canonical wisdom and institutional vision.

Ultimately, all these responsibilities converge upon the supreme principle of ecclesiastical law, expressed in canon 1752:

Salus animarum suprema lex est - the salvation of souls is the supreme law.

A Church that remains faithful to this principle will be better equipped to safeguard its unity, fulfil its mission, preserve its credibility and contribute meaningfully to the building of a more just, peaceful and humane Nigerian society.